

9.2 Singulate Mean Age at Marriage – SMAM

Mean age at the first marriage or Singulate mean age at marriage – SMAM is a summary index of the distribution of ages of males and females at the time of marriage in a population. The index reflects the average number of years, which a group of people who enter marriage at the age of 50, would remain as bachelors, taking into account the patterns of marriage that currently exists. The mean age arrived this way, could be used as an estimate of the mean age at which persons in the population get married. The mean age at first marriage is not a direct measure of the actual age at marriage of individuals; rather, it is a statistical estimate derived from the age distribution of unmarried persons in the population. This index is calculated based on the assumption that prevailing marriage patterns will remain constant in the future. The index enables the analysis of the average age at entry into marriage, marriage postponement, and changes in marital behavior.

Table 9.8 shows the mean age at marriage for males and females as revealed by the censuses conducted over the 71-year period from 1953 to the 2024.

Table 9.8 : Mean Age at Marriage, 1953–2024

Census Year	Mean Age at Marriage (Years)		
	Male	Female	Difference
1953	27.2	20.9	6.3
1963	27.9	22.1	5.8
1971	28.0	23.5	4.5
1981	27.9	24.4	3.5
2012	27.2	23.4	3.8
2024	29.2	25.6	3.6

Although there were no major changes in the average age of marriage for males between 1953 and 2012, by 2024 the average age of marriage for males has increased to 29.2 years. This is a 2 year significant increase from 2012.

The average age at marriage for females has gradually increased since 1953 and during the period 1971 to 2012 the value was stagnant between 23 to 24. However, by 2024, the average age at marriage has increased significantly to 25.6 years.

While the average age gap between males and females at marriage was over 6 years in 1953, it has narrowed to 3.6 years by 2024.

Mean Age at Marriage by Sector

Table 9.9 : Mean Age at Marriage by Sector, 2024

Sector	Mean Age at Marriage (Years)		
	Male	Female	Difference
Sri Lanka	29.2	25.6	3.6
Urban *	29.8	26.6	3.2
Rural	29.0	25.4	3.6
Estate Rural **	28.4	24.5	3.9

* In 2024 information was collected separately for "Urban" and "Estate Urban" sectors, for comparison with the 2012 Census data, these two sectors have been combined and presented as "Urban".

** In the 2012 Census, the sector was identified as "Estate", whereas in the 2024 Census it is referred to as "Estate Rural."